

CoC 1920s: NOT ANOTHER TELEGRAM

Event 93 · Call of Cthulhu 7th Ed · New York City, 1924 · 6 Investigators · 3 hours 30 min · Saturday 7:00 PM

Fawly Towers meets At the Mountains of Madness. Funny right up until it's absolutely horrifying.

KEEPER'S TRUTH — DO NOT SHARE

In 1924, a mediocre occultist named Reginald Ashworth attempted to summon a servitor of Nyarlathotep at his Manhattan brownstone during a private gathering. He failed — almost. He didn't summon it fully; he invited it in. The entity — a Skinless Watcher — partially manifested and now haunts a trail of bodies across three locations in New York, pulling itself further into the physical world with each soul it consumes. Ashworth is dead (first victim) but sent a telegram to his old friend Professor Edna Whitmore before he died. Whitmore has gone missing. The investigators are connected to Whitmore and have each received a forwarded copy of the same cryptic telegram via her secretary. DEADLINE: midnight of the same day. Scenario begins ~8PM — 4 hours remain. The Skinless Watcher cannot be shot, punched, or arrested. It can be banished — through the ritual in the Faceless Codex, and crucially, through what remains of Charles Henderson's humanity inside it. The scenario rewards talking over fighting. Investigators who try to shoot their way through will find it deeply unsatisfying and somewhat expensive in Sanity.

■ INTRODUCTION — MISS PRUITT'S OFFICE (~15 min)

Locations: 44 West 53rd Street, 3rd floor — Professor Whitmore's office

Miss Hazel Pruitt (44, efficient, quietly terrified) sits behind a desk covered in unopened post. She forwards the telegram: Whitmore received it four days ago, packed a bag, and left immediately — for the brownstone she was explicitly told not to visit. Comedy beat: Mickey (P.I.) may point out this is objectively very stupid. THE TELEGRAM: 'EDNA STOP THE WHEEL IS TURNING STOP DO NOT COME TO THE BROWNSTONE STOP THE SKIN DOES NOT FIT ANYMORE STOP REGINALD STOP' Whitmore left a sealed envelope marked OPEN IF THINGS GO WRONG: 'Go to the Blue Orchid. 133rd Street, Harlem. Find Delia Monroe. She knows.' Password this week: Sassafras. Open from 9PM. Also: each investigator receives a copy of the telegram Whitmore forwarded through her secretary. The conceit: it is literally another telegram — and experienced CoC players can lean into this. Clarence Fitch (hotel bellhop) can mutter 'Oh, not another one of those.' One investigator may groan aloud. This comedic self-awareness must dissolve within 20 minutes into genuine dread, as the scenario earns its horror.

Clues / handouts: The forwarded telegram (handout) · Whitmore's sealed note · Miss Pruitt's briefing

■ ACT ONE — THE BLUE ORCHID JAZZ CLUB (~45 min)

Locations: 133rd Street, Harlem — entry through a laundry · Password: Sassafras

Warm amber light, jazz, the smell of good bourbon and tobacco. Lucky Beaumont has automatic success gaining Delia Monroe's trust. DELIA 'DIAMOND' MONROE — lounge singer, 30s, has seen too much to be frightened of the investigators: (1) Met Ashworth twice at salon events — his eyes were wrong in a way she couldn't name. (2) Met 'the thing wearing Henderson's face' (the Herald) and knew immediately it was not Henderson. (3) Told Whitmore to stay away from the brownstone. Whitmore thanked her and went anyway. (4) Whitmore came to the club three days ago. (5) Left Delia a sealed envelope for emergencies -- inside: a hand-drawn map of the brownstone basement including the location of a concealed panel opening to a ritual space. THE HERALD — Charles Henderson, 44, insurance clerk, arrives at the club mid-conversation. He attended Ashworth's final salon because Ashworth owed him money. He is now partially the Skinless Watcher's vehicle. Psychology: he is wrong in a way that is hard to specify — movement slightly off, lips sometimes move without sound. SAN 0/1D4. He asks for 'the items she left.' The correct response is to talk to him — really talk to him. He is still, somewhere inside, Mr Henderson. Dark comedy beat: knocks over a vase leaving. Apologises reflexively. Best resolution: reach Henderson; save him for Act Three's crucial Phase 3 moment.

Clues / handouts: Delia's information · Whitmore's concealed map envelope · Henderson first appearance [SAN 0/1D4]

Pacing: Keep the comedy atmospheric, never winking. It must dissolve into dread as they leave the club heading for the brownstone.

■ ACT TWO — THE BROWNSTONE (~60 min)

Locations: East 64th Street — Drawing Room · Library · Basement

Drawing Room: furniture moved, chalk traces scraped away. Family portraits of the Ashworth line — similar features, growing increasingly intense across generations. Three generations of collecting, and then Reginald. Library: Ashworth's journal documents the summoning attempt — timeline, the Faceless Codex reference, 'it came when I opened the gap.' Locked cabinet behind the desk (Locksmith or Spot for the key): the Faceless Codex. Library Use to find relevant passages; Occult to understand them. Hard to read fully — costs 1D4 SAN and takes 20 minutes. Contains the banishment ritual. Investigators must restore a specific chalk circle and read specific passages aloud. BASEMENT — WHITMORE FOUND: a chalk circle on the stone floor, mostly smeared. Candles burned to nothing. Professor Edna Whitmore (68, formidable, brilliant, stubborn) is alive, tied to a chair, blindfolded, earplugs in. She did this to herself with trembling hands. She explains immediately: the Watcher cannot find you if it cannot see or hear you. WHAT WHITMORE KNOWS: it is a servitor entity, not a Great Old One — powerful but not a god. Arrival at midnight if not banished. The Codex contains the method. She needs the investigators to restore the circle and help with the ritual — she cannot do it alone and weakened. THE HERALD RETURNS: descends the stairs mid-briefing. Knocks over a vase. Apologises. He is here to prevent the ritual. Can be persuaded (Psychology Hard) or physically contained. Either way he is crucial in Act Three.

Clues / handouts: Ashworth's journal · The Faceless Codex (banishment ritual) · Whitmore's full briefing · Herald reappears

Pacing: Protect the Codex narratively — make sure it reaches Act Three. Henderson must not be destroyed. He matters in Phase 3.

■ ACT THREE — THE WATCHER IN THE GLASS (~55 min)

Locations: Ashworth brownstone basement — the ritual circle and the oval standing mirror

Phase 1 — Restoring the Circle: Whitmore guides investigators to re-chalk the binding circle. Occult roll per investigator contributing (Normal difficulty with Whitmore guiding, Hard without). Each failure costs 5 minutes toward midnight. Phase 2 — The Ritual: Whitmore leads three investigators reading from the Faceless Codex. Three consecutive Occult rolls (Hard). The Watcher begins to assemble in the oval standing mirror — not fully present, building toward manifestation. SAN 1D6/1D10 on first sight. SAN 1D10/1D20 as it approaches full manifestation. Failure in the reading breaks the paralysis — the Watcher can act for 1D3 rounds. Phase 3 — Henderson's Choice: the Watcher can be fully and permanently banished if someone reaches Henderson — the remnant of the man inside the vessel. This requires speaking to him, not to the monster. Really speak to him. The photo of his wife Margaret (found in his jacket pocket if searched in Act One). His name. His ordinary life. What he was going to do at the party (raise the subject of the money Ashworth owed him). Henderson's voice, from somewhere inside: 'My wife's name is Margaret. I was going to raise the subject of the money at the party.' A beat. 'I'm going to go home now.' The mirror fractures. The Watcher screams. Then: silence. If Henderson cannot be reached: the ritual alone can banish (with cost — roll consequence escalates, and one investigator must voluntarily touch the mirror surface to anchor the banishment — SAN 1D8 and a Hard POW roll).

Clues / handouts: Faceless Codex (Phase 2) · Henderson remnant (Phase 3) · Margaret's photograph if found on Henderson

Pacing: At 2:45: midnight is 15 minutes away. The mirror surface begins to show movement. Henderson has not spoken yet. Push.

■ EPILOGUE (~15 min)

Locations: The brownstone and beyond — address each investigator personally

Whitmore: recovers fully. Publishes nothing. Retires to Vermont. Keeps an extraordinary number of cats. Henderson: his wife Margaret receives a knock at the door three weeks later. She is not asked to explain what she sees when she opens it. Helen (Reporter): she has a story she will never be able to file. Whether that's tragedy or relief — only she knows. Mickey (P.I.): has stopped waking up at 3AM. The photograph he burned is gone. What replaced it in the dreams is better, but wrong in a different way. Lucky (Musician): heard something in the ritual — a note he has never been able to reproduce since. He is still trying. Vivienne (Heiress): the corridor in her dreams no longer has a door at the end. She has stopped being relieved about this. Finch (Academic): has written three papers that obliquely reference what he saw. All three were rejected for insufficient evidence. He keeps them.

Pacing: Give each investigator one sentence that closes their hook. The comedy and the horror both deserve a real ending.

KEY NPCS

Delia 'Diamond' Monroe *Blue Orchid lounge singer, 30s*

Sharp, warm, has seen too much to be frightened easily. Charm 75%, Insight 65%

Won't be played. Won't be patronised. Lucky has automatic success on first contact. Knows: Ashworth's wrong eyes; Henderson is not Henderson; Whitmore went anyway.

Prof. Edna Whitmore *Academic, 68 — missing professor*

INT 17 EDU 18 · Occult 75%, Library Use 80%, Archaeology 65% · HP 11 · SAN 40 (significantly depleted)

Brilliant, stubborn, self-blindfolded in the basement. Tells the truth without prompting — no games, no time. Needs the investigators. Will do the binding herself if they won't, but she is weakened.

The Herald (Charles Henderson) *Insurance clerk, 44 — partially the Watcher's vehicle*

Pale, thin, grey suit. Movement slightly wrong. Lips occasionally moving without sound.

He is still, somewhere inside, Mr Henderson. Wife: Margaret. He was going to raise the subject of the money at the party. Must be reached in Phase 3. Must NOT be destroyed before then.

The Skinless Watcher *Nyarlahotep servitor — assembles in the oval mirror*

POW 22 · SAN 1D6/1D10 first sight · 1D10/1D20 near full manifestation · Cannot be shot or harmed conventionally

Banished via Codex ritual (Phase 2) PLUS Henderson's voluntary departure (Phase 3). Phase 2 alone can work but costs a mirror-anchor and a Hard POW roll at cost. Best resolution combines both.

Miss Hazel Pruitt *Whitmore's secretary, 44 — Introduction only*

Efficient, quietly terrified. Has been sitting at this desk since Whitmore left, four days ago.

Delivers the setup cleanly. Leave her in the Introduction.

Clarence Fitch *Hotel bellhop — one line, one comedic beat*

The scenario's opening note of self-aware comedy. 'Oh, not another one of those.'

The comedy must be earned. It must be gone within 20 minutes.

INVESTIGATORS

Helen Cross *Reporter, 29 — New York Tribune*

INT 80 POW 65 DEX 65 · HP 12 · SAN 65

Fast Talk 75%, Psychology 60%, Spot Hidden 60%. Hook: editor doesn't know she's here. If she files the story, it makes her career.

Dr Edmund Graves *Physician, 45*

INT 75 POW 60 CON 70 · HP 14 · SAN 60

Medicine 80%, First Aid 75%. Hook: examined one of Ashworth's early victims. Something about the skin has been nagging him for three weeks.

Mickey Doyle *Private Eye, 38*

STR 70 DEX 70 CON 65 · HP 14 · SAN 60 · .38 revolver (3D6)

Spot Hidden 70%, Psychology 60%, Locksmith 50%. Hook: photographed something in Ashworth's window. Burned the photo. Still waking up at 3AM.

Louis 'Lucky' Beaumont *Jazz musician, 32*

APP 80 POW 75 DEX 75 · HP 13 · SAN 75

Charm 75%, Listen 70%. Automatic success with Delia. Hook: hears wrong notes forming patterns. Was not imagining it.

Vivienne St. Claire *Heiress, 34*

APP 90 INT 80 · HP 11 · SAN 70 · pocket revolver (.22)

Credit Rating 90%, Persuade 70%, Charm 75%. Hook: funded Whitmore's research (\$3,000). Dreams of a corridor with a door she's glad to wake before opening.

Prof. Walter Finch *Academic — Whitmore's graduate student*

INT 80 EDU 90 · HP 11 · SAN 65

Library Use 75%, Occult 50%. Hook: recognised two symbols from Whitmore's frantic letters. Shouldn't have recognised any of them.

HANDOUTS

The Telegram — 'EDNA STOP THE WHEEL IS TURNING STOP DO NOT COME TO THE BROWNSTONE STOP THE SKIN DOES NOT FIT ANYMORE STOP REGINALD STOP'

Whitmore's Note — Sealed envelope — 'Go to the Blue Orchid. 133rd St, Harlem. Delia Monroe. She knows.' Password: Sassafras

H1 — Newspaper cutting — socialite death at Ashworth brownstone listed as cardiac event. Two weeks ago. Perfectly healthy 34-year-old.

H2 — Ashworth's Journal (in library) — summoning timeline; 'it came when I opened the gap'; Faceless Codex referenced as key to undoing it

H3 — Faceless Codex page — ancient notation; partial translation readable without full Library Use; banishment ritual within; costs 1D4 SAN to read fully

SAN TABLE:

- Henderson (the Herald) — movement wrong **0/1D4**
- Codex — reading the full ritual **1D4**
- Watcher assembles in mirror — first sight **1D6/1D10**

- Watcher near full manifestation **1D10/1D20**
- Touching mirror surface (anchor option) **1D8**
- Henderson's departure / mirror fractures **0/1D3 — but a different kind**

KEY ROLLS: Occult (Normal) — restore circle with Whitmore guiding · Occult (Hard ×3) — ritual banishment · Psychology (Hard) — reach Henderson / identify Herald as wrong · Locksmith or Spot (Normal) — find Codex key · Library Use (Normal) — find relevant Codex passages · Occult (Hard) — understand them · POW (Hard) — mirror anchor if Henderson cannot be reached